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To call ‘this ongoing crisis an emergency is not only puzzling, it’s costly.’

MARY CONNAUGHTON, *Pioneer Institute*

Shelter system better but still ‘emergency’

By Samantha J. Gross
GLOBE STAFF

The number of families living in the state’s once-overwhelmed emergency shelter system is half of what it was at its peak. Governor Maura Healey insists the costs, which ballooned to \$1 billion last year, are coming down, and the government is six months ahead of its deadline to end the widespread use of hotels and motels as family shelters.

But the Healey administration says the shelter system is still in crisis.

State officials last Friday extended a

formal emergency declaration, asserting that even though the number of families in shelter is below the cap set by the Legislature, the state still cannot keep up with the demand. Healey officials say they issued the declaration specifically so they can continue to impose restrictions on shelters, such as limiting who gets priority for beds and how long they can stay.

Massachusetts Housing Secretary Ed Augustus wrote in a declaration that despite the closure of hotels and lower expenses, “economic uncertainty, high

SHELTERS, Page A4

Steward sues ex-CEO over millions in pay

In court, bankrupt health care firm says de la Torre, others looted company funds

By Hanna Krueger
and Elizabeth Koh

GLOBE STAFF

In an explosive new filing, Steward Health Care accused its founder and other former top officials of plundering the hospital chain of hundreds of millions of dollars in a scheme that directly led to the collapse of the once-high flying, Boston-born company.

The filing this week in Steward’s bankruptcy case alleges that former



FOLLOW-UP

chief executive Ralph de la Torre and three other current or former executives and board members defrauded the company of some \$262 million. The executives also sunk about \$1.1 billion into five flailing hospitals in Florida to satiate de la Torre’s “personal desire to build a hospital empire,” ultimately

overpaying about \$200 million for the properties, according to the complaint.

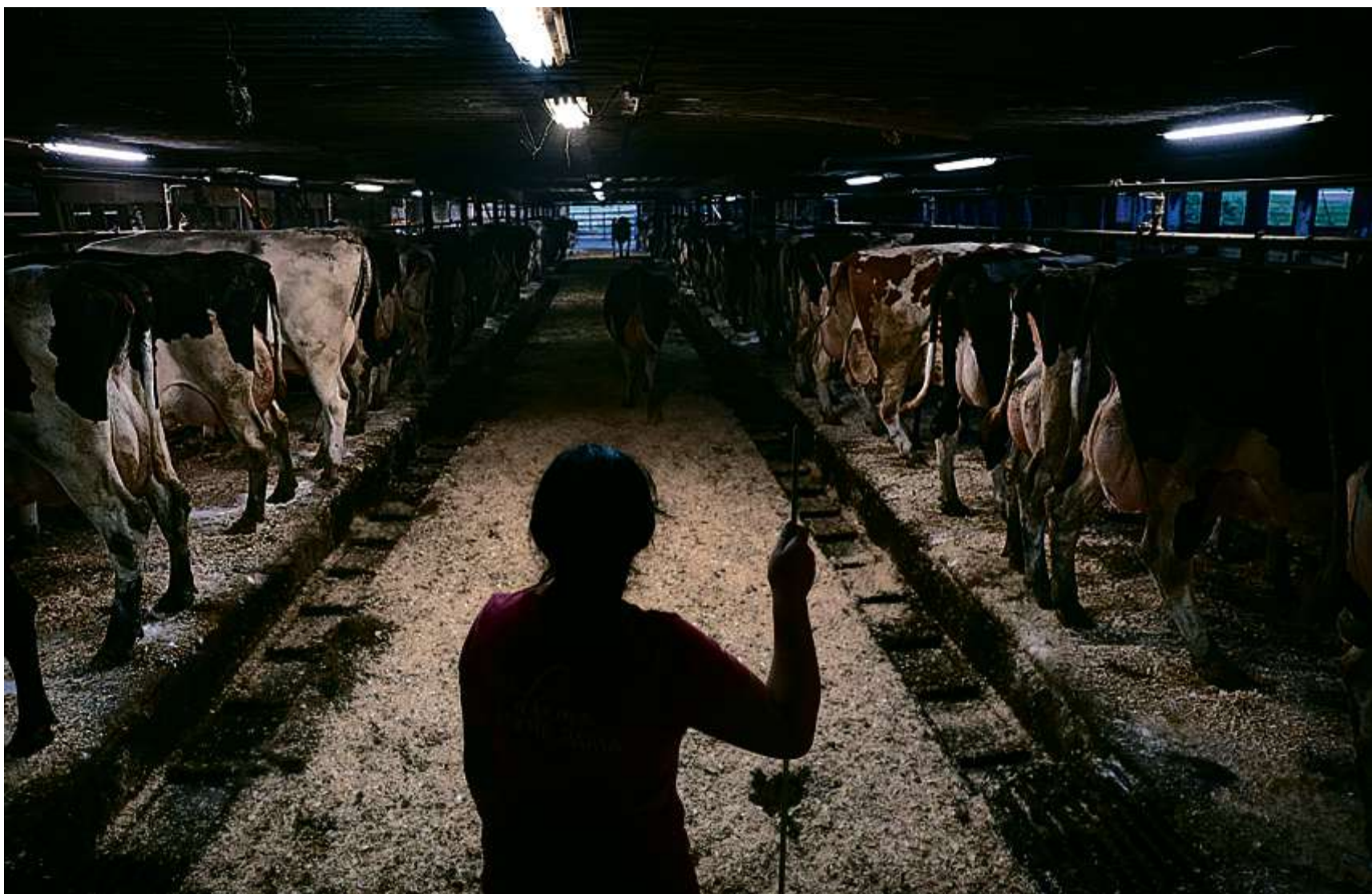
Steward is currently being run by a court-appointed administrator, and the company is trying to claw back funds from its former leaders to pay off scores of creditors. This new filing is based on a report filed last month by the company’s internal investigation committee.

It paints a deeply unflattering portrait of de la Torre, who was once lauded as a health care visionary but became, to many, the personification of corporate greed. The three other

STEWARDS, Page A10

WORKING TOGETHER TO STAY TOGETHER

A Vermont dairy farmer has the help he needed, and a Guatemalan immigrant is able to give her growing family a different sort of home. But now it’s all at risk.



CRAIG F. WALKER/GLOBE STAFF

Wuendy Bernardo watched over the cows during an early morning shift at the dairy farm where she lives in Orleans County, Vt.

By Paul Heintz

GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

ORLEANS COUNTY, Vt. —

As the youngest of 12 siblings, John Morin grew up accustomed to a crowd in the house on his father’s dairy farm.

Half a century later, the modest, two-story home on the Vermont side of the Canadian border remains just as bustling. Morin, 56, has no children. But for the past decade, Guatemalan farm worker Wuendy Bernardo, her partner, and their growing family, which now includes seven kids, have lived on the second floor.

“I like the rumbling upstairs,” Morin said. “When no one’s in the house, it’s eerie.”

Morin hired Bernardo and her partner out of necessity. He couldn’t find Americans willing to milk his cows, raise his calves, and shovel out the barn — physically demanding work with long hours and modest wages. Over time, the relationship between the self-described conservative farmer and his migrant workers has deepened.

“I consider them more than just employees,” he said. “They’re part of the family.”

The feeling is mutual. As

FARM, Page A6

CBS said it will ax “The Late Show With Stephen Colbert” in May, after the host spoke out against Paramount. A4.

Public radio broadcasters are bracing for severe cuts after the Senate voted to claw back over \$1 billion in funding. **B5.**

The state is closing part of a lane of Memorial Drive, amid fears that a large condo building nearby might collapse. **B1.**



Out of the frying pan

Friday: Much better. High 82-87. Low 63-68.

Saturday: Another one. High 81-86. Low 67-72.

Weather and Comics, G6-7. Obituaries, C9.

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Death toll reaches 10 in Fall River fire

Bodycam footage shows desperate rescue efforts

By Danny McDonald
and Nick Stoico

GLOBE STAFF

and Ava Berger
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

FALL RIVER — Another resident of Gabriel House died this week, bringing the death toll from the fire at the assisted living facility to 10, as more details emerged Thursday of the harrowing rescue operation by first responders.

Brenda Cropper, 66, died in a hospital Wednesday after being critically injured in Sunday’s fire, the state’s deadliest since 1984, officials said.

The cause and origin of the fire, which also left some 30 people injured, including five firefighters, remains under investigation by city and state fire officials.

Fall River police released bodycam footage that showed

rescue efforts underway inside the burning building. In addition to around 50 firefighters, 13 Fall River police officers participated in rescue efforts.

Footage shows police opening an exterior door to a hallway as a woman stepped outside.

“We need you out, there’s a huge fire,” the officer tells the

► **Fall River residents look for answers. B1.**

woman as a man with a flashlight exited behind her.

The officer then stepped into the hallway and began knocking on doors. He opened one and found a person sitting on their bed.

The video also shows the officer kicking in a door while a firefighter breaks down another door with an ax.

“Everybody out!” the officer shouted.

As they arrived at the scene, firefighters and police

FIRE, Page B4

A sound investment

When flutists are looking for something special, no matter the cost, they come here

By Hiawatha Bray

GLOBE STAFF

Hilary Abigana lifts the golden flute to her lips and gently blows. And for a few magical seconds, the room resounds with melodies rich and sweet.

It doesn’t take long for Abigana to make her point. In the right hands, a \$100,000 flute is worth every penny. That’s the price of the 14-karat gold flute Abigana is playing. It’s a price that well-heeled musicians are happy to pay. And when these affluent flutists go shopping, it’s quite likely they’ll be shopping in the Boston area.

The US auto industry isn’t what it used to be, but if it were, Greater Boston would be the Detroit of flute making — home to a host of world-class manufacturers. And unlike Detroit, the Boston area has retained its crown, as artisans trained at well-established companies have continually launched new firms of their own.

William S. Haynes of Acton began Powell Flutes of Maynard, where Abigana, an award-winning flutist, works as sales manager. But



DAVID L. RYAN/GLOBE STAFF

the region is also home to Brannen Brothers Flutemakers of Woburn, Nagahara Flutes of Chelmsford, Levit Flute in Natick, Di Zhao Flutes of Westford, Burkart Flutes and Piccolos in Shirley, and Emanuel Flutes of North Andover.

These firms make flutes that range in price from a few thousand up to six figures. Their instruments are prized by classical soloists and orchestral players worldwide, as well as jazz musicians and even the occasional rock star such as Ian

FLUTES, Page A10

Eduardo Gomez worked on one of the instruments at Powell Flutes in Maynard. Many Powell veterans have launched their own companies.